

# The HSBC Question Playbook

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**For:** Janak · **Prepared:** 12 August 2026 · **Covers:** every other high-probability question in the HSBC video assessment, each broken down in full — what it's really testing, the structure, a model answer, where your technical knowledge fits, the humour option, and the traps.

**How this fits with your other documents.** "Why HSBC" and "Why this role" got their own deep-dive ( [hsbc-why-from-first-principles.pdf](#) ). This playbook does the same job for **everything else they're likely to ask** — and, more importantly, teaches you the **decoder**: a way to work out, in your two-minute prep window, what *any* question is really probing, so you're never caught by a question you didn't rehearse.

Everything here is coaching **INFERRED** built on the verified research in your earlier briefings; question likelihoods come from candidate reports and prep sources gathered previously [\[1\]\[2\]\[3\]](#). Model answers are **skeletons to adapt in your own words** — **never memorise**: HSBC's video is one take, human-reviewed, authenticity-checked, and reading generated text on camera is against its rules [\[4\]\[5\]\[6\]](#).

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## Part 1 — The decoder: how to read any question in 10 seconds

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Every question in this assessment is a costume. Underneath, it is always probing one of **five things** — and once you spot which, you know what your answer must contain.

1. **A value probe.** HSBC scores against its four values: **We value difference · We succeed together · We take responsibility · We get it done** [\[7\]](#). A question about teamwork, culture, disagreement, or other perspectives is a value probe.
2. **A strengths probe.** The Cappfinity platform is strengths-based: it wants to know what you're genuinely good at *and energised by* — and it cross-checks your answers for consistency, so faking reads worse than honesty [\[8\]](#).
3. **A judgement probe.** Situations with pressure, ambiguity, or ethics: they want calm triage — what's urgent, who to involve, what's the right thing.
4. **A commercial probe.** News, markets, "what interests you": they want evidence you follow the real world and can connect it to HSBC.

5. **A communication probe.** Every single answer, whatever else it is, is also this one: can you structure a thought and land it in two minutes?

**The 10-second decode in your prep window:** ask *"which of the five is this?"* → pick the matching story or flag from your bank → jot the four-beat skeleton → record. That's the whole method.

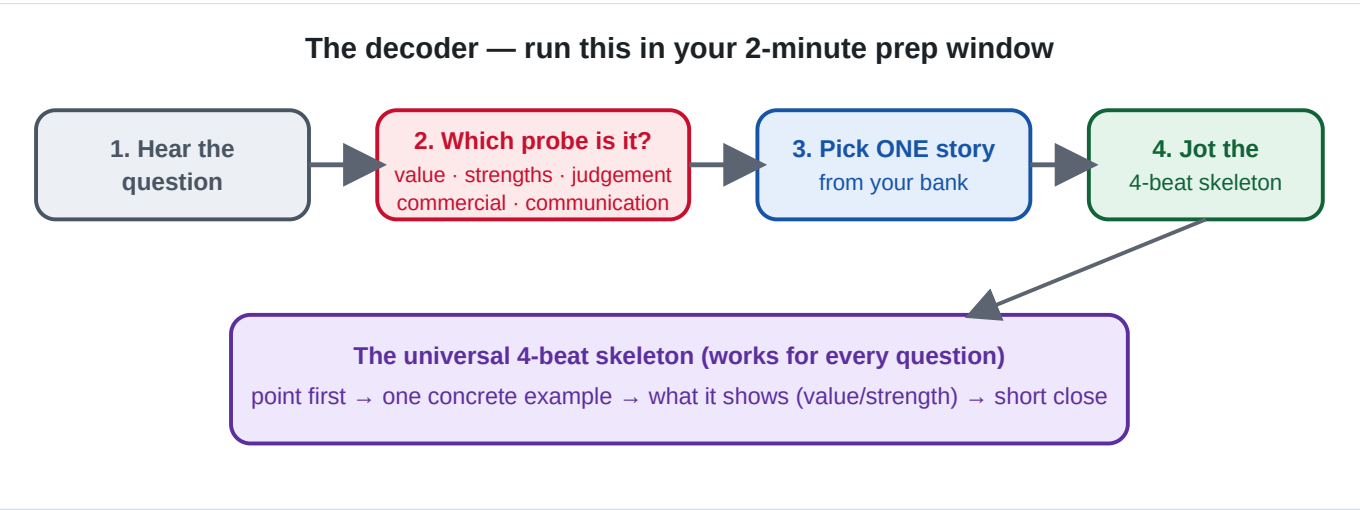


Diagram 1 — The decoder: identify the probe, pick the story, run the skeleton. Never be surprised again.

## Build your story bank first (30 minutes, once)

Before question-by-question practice, write **6–8 true stories** from your life — university, work, clubs, sport, personal projects — and tag each with the values and strengths it shows. The whole assessment then becomes matching, not inventing. Fill a grid like this:

| Your story (one line)                                                     | Succeed together | Value difference | Take responsibility | Get it done | Strength it shows      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|---------------------|-------------|------------------------|
| e.g. "Organised the society event when the venue cancelled at 48h notice" | ✓                |                  | ✓                   | ✓           | calm under pressure    |
| e.g. "Group project where I disagreed with the lead's approach"           | ✓                | ✓                |                     |             | constructive challenge |
| ...6 more of yours...                                                     |                  |                  |                     |             |                        |

Aim for coverage: at least one story per value, at least one failure, one conflict/disagreement, one leadership, one deadline. **Each story must survive a follow-up question** — that's the test of "true enough."

## Part 2 — The behavioural core (the STAR questions)

These are the "tell me about a time..." questions — a **value probe wearing a story costume**.

HSBC's own advice is the **STAR** structure, in its words: "*explain the situation you faced; the specific task required; the action that you took; and the result of this action*" — and it adds that examples "*don't have to be drawn from work*" [4]. Add a one-line **Reflection** at the end (what you learned) — prep sources call this STAR+R [3].

**The one thing most candidates get wrong is the proportions.** They spend a minute setting the scene and 15 seconds on what *they* did. Invert it:

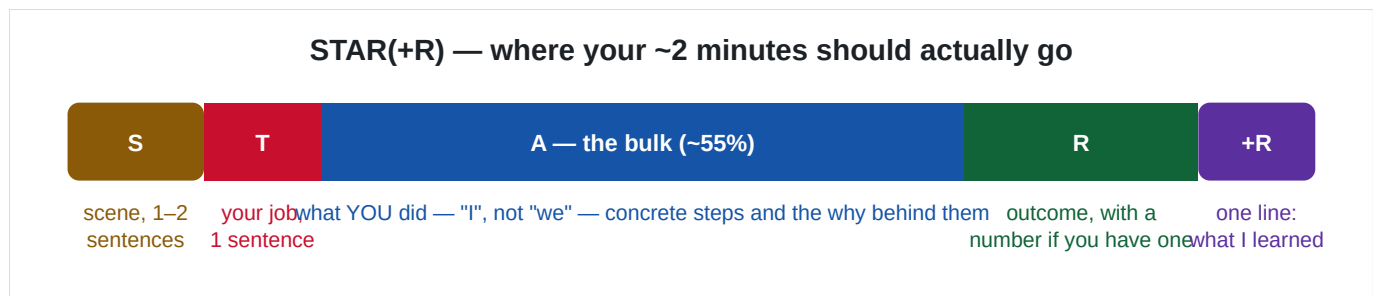


Diagram 2 — The action is the answer. Scene-setting is just the doorway.

### Q: "Tell me about a time you worked in a team to achieve a common goal"

- **What it's really testing:** *We succeed together* — and whether you can describe collaboration without vanishing into "we did this, we did that." The reviewer needs to see **your** contribution inside the team's win.
- **Structure:** STAR with one twist — name the *friction* the team faced (different views, time pressure, a weak link) and show your action resolving it. Frictionless teamwork stories score low because nothing was demonstrated.
- **Skeleton to adapt:** "*The clearest example is [scene, one line]. My role was [task]. The tricky part was [friction]. So I [action 1 — usually listening/organising], then [action 2 — the concrete contribution], and I made a point of [action showing you lifted someone else]. We [result]. What I took from it is [reflection tied to succeed-together].*"
- **Trap:** claiming the whole win. Give credit to the team *by name of role* ("our designer's idea, which I then...") — generosity reads as confidence.
- **Humour option (light, in the scene beat):** "*This was our group project — four people, three opinions per person, one deadline.*"

## Q: "Tell me about a time you showed leadership / led by example"

- **What it's really testing:** *We get it done + We take responsibility.* Crucially, at your career stage they are **not** expecting authority — they're expecting **initiative**: the moment you stepped up without being asked.
- **Structure:** STAR, where the Task beat explicitly says *nobody asked me to or there was a gap*. That single line converts an ordinary story into a leadership story.
- **Skeleton:** *"I'd define leadership as stepping up before you're asked, so my example is [scene]. There was a gap: [what wasn't happening]. I decided to [action — organising, deciding, unblocking], and to bring others with me I [how you got buy-in]. The result was [outcome]. It taught me [reflection — e.g. that leading is mostly making it easier for others to do their part]."*
- **Trap:** picking a story where you had the title (captain, president) but describing no *behaviour*. The title is scenery; the behaviour is the answer.

## Q: "Tell me about a time something didn't go to plan" (failure / resilience)

- **What it's really testing:** *We take responsibility* — and authenticity. This is the question where the strengths platform's honesty-checking matters most: a fake failure ("my plan was too excellent") reads instantly as evasive <sup>[8]</sup>.
- **Structure:** STAR, but the Result beat splits in two — **the honest outcome** ("it didn't work / we missed it") and **the recovery** (what you did about it). End on the reflection; this question, more than any other, is *scored on the reflection*.
- **Skeleton:** *"A real one: [scene]. My plan was [what you intended]. It went wrong because [honest cause — include your share of it]. What I did next was [recovery action]. The honest outcome was [result — it's fine if it's mixed]. What changed in how I work is [specific behavioural change — this is the money line]."*
- **Trap #1:** blaming others. Even if others contributed, own your slice — that is the value being probed. **Trap #2:** choosing a catastrophic failure. Pick one with real stakes but a good learning arc.
- **Humour option (self-aware, in the scene):** *"I learned this one the hard way, which I'm told is the memorable way."*

## Q: "Tell me about a decision you made without all the information"

- **What it's really testing:** judgement probe — calm triage under ambiguity, the day-to-day reality of banking. They want your **decision process**, not the decision.
- **Structure:** STAR where the Action beat is a visible *method*: what you knew, what you couldn't know, how you weighed it, what safeguard you built in.

- **Skeleton:** "[Scene]. I had to decide by [deadline] and I was missing [the gap]. I worked out what I did know: [facts]. For what I couldn't know, I [assumption/quick check/asked X]. I decided [choice], and I built in a fallback: [safeguard]. It [result]. My takeaway: with incomplete information, the job is to make the decision reversible where you can — and then actually decide."
- **Why this one is worth extra polish:** that last line is how bankers think about risk. Saying it in your own words quietly signals you'll fit the desk.

## Q: "Tell me about a time someone challenged your view / you worked with people different from you"

- **What it's really testing:** We value difference — HSBC's first value, and the one its whole East-meets-West identity rests on. They want evidence you actually *changed or widened* your thinking, not that you tolerated disagreement politely.
- **Structure:** STAR where the hinge is the moment you **took the other view seriously** — and the Result shows the outcome was *better because of it*.
- **Skeleton:** "[Scene — a genuine disagreement or a genuinely different perspective]. My initial view was [position]. [Person] saw it differently because [their reasoning — show you understood it, not just heard it]. What changed my mind was [the moment]. We ended up [outcome better than your original plan]. It's made me [reflection — e.g. now I ask the quietest person first]."
- **Trap:** a story where you "listened" and then did your original plan anyway. That's the opposite of the value.

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## Part 3 — The personal set (intro, strengths, weakness, energisers)

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### Q: "Tell me about yourself" / the warm-up

- **What it's really testing:** communication probe + first impression. Treat the warm-up/practice question **as if it's scored** — sources disagree on whether it is, so assume yes <sup>[2]</sup>.
- **Structure:** **Present** → **Path** → **Future** (~90 seconds). *Now:* who you are plus one hook relevant to the role. *Path:* two experiences showing the skills this job needs (people + analysis). *Future:* why this points at HSBC's client-facing side.
- **Skeleton:** "I'm [name], a [degree/stage] at [place], and the short version of me is: I like understanding how things work and I like people — which is roughly the job description here. Two things shaped that: [experience 1 — the people/relationship one], and [experience 2 — the

*analytical one]. Put together, that's what's pulled me toward the relationship side of Corporate and Institutional Banking — and specifically to HSBC, for reasons I suspect I'll get to."*

- **Humour option:** *"Fair warning — I've done enough research on HSBC that I could probably fail an interview FOR it on trivia alone."* Then move on.

## Q: "What are your strengths?"

- **What it's really testing:** a direct strengths probe — and a **consistency anchor**: the platform will compare this answer with your personality-scale answers elsewhere, so name strengths that are *actually true of you* [8].
- **Structure:** ONE strength (two max) → crisp proof → why it matters for *this* role.
- **Skeleton:** *"The one people would name first is [strength — e.g. I make complicated things clear / I build trust quickly / I finish things]. Proof: [30-second concrete example]. I think it matters here because the relationship job is exactly that: [one line connecting strength to the Relationship Manager's work — understanding a client and bringing the bank to them]."*
- **Trap:** the strengths shopping list. Five strengths in a row proves none of them.

## Q: "What's your greatest weakness?"

- **What it's really testing:** self-awareness + honesty. The disguised humble-brag ("I work too hard") is the single most eye-rolled answer in interviewing — and on a strengths-based platform it also reads as *inconsistent*.
- **Structure:** a **real, non-fatal** weakness → concrete steps you're taking → evidence of progress. Never pick something core to the role (don't say "detail" for an analyst job).
- **Skeleton:** *"A real one: [weakness — e.g. I over-prepare and can be slow to just start / I find it hard to delegate / I'm hesitant to speak first in big groups]. Where it's bitten me: [tiny example]. What I do about it: [specific habit — a time-box, a rule, a forcing function]. It's improving: [small proof]."*
- **Humour option (this is the natural home for self-deprecation):** *"My weakness is I get properly stuck into detail — my notes are either an asset or a small novel, depending on the day. I'm learning to ask which one the moment needs."*

## Q: "What energises you?" / "What do you do in your free time?"

- **What it's really testing:** the purest strengths-based question — Cappfinity's core theory is that people perform best at what energises them [8]. Free-time questions are the same probe in casual clothes: they reveal what you choose when nobody's assigning it.
- **Structure:** the true thing → why it energises you → (optional, light) the bridge to work.

- **Skeleton:** *"Honestly, [true interest]. What I love about it is [the underlying driver — solving, competing, building, connecting people]. And I've noticed the same driver is what I enjoy in work settings: [one line]."* The bridge must be feather-light — don't turn five-a-side football into a leadership seminar.
- **Trap:** answering with what you think sounds impressive. If it's not true, the consistency machine and the follow-up question will both find you.

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## Part 4 — The commercial-awareness set

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### Q: "Tell me about a recent news story / macro event and how it affected markets"

- **What it's really testing:** commercial probe — do you follow the world, and can you *connect* it to money and to HSBC? This is where your firm research becomes an unfair advantage: most candidates recite a headline; you can run the **event** → **transmission** → **so-what** → **view** chain.
- **The four-beat structure (~90–120 seconds):** 1. **Event** — name ONE, precisely and recently (a rates decision, an inflation print, a trade/tariff move, a China development). 2. **Transmission** — *how* it moves markets, one chain: rates → borrowing costs → currencies → company decisions. One chain, told clearly, beats three chains gestured at. 3. **So-what for HSBC** — this is your standout beat, and your firm knowledge supplies it. Two evergreen moves: *rates* → "HSBC earns roughly half its income from the gap between what it earns and pays on money, so rate moves hit it directly — which is exactly why it's pushing into fee businesses like wealth and payments." *Trade/China* → "anything that redraws trade routes runs straight through HSBC — it's the world's biggest trade-finance bank, so rerouted supply chains are literally its business." 4. **Your view** — one sentence of opinion, with one risk or counterpoint. An opinion held lightly is the mark of someone worth talking to.
- **Skeleton:** *"The one I've been following is [event]. The mechanism matters: [transmission chain]. For HSBC specifically, [so-what]. My own read is [view] — though the counter-argument is [risk], which is why I'd watch [indicator]."*
- **Preparation:** keep **two events warm** (one rates/economy, one trade/China or a sector you genuinely like) and re-check them the morning you record.
- **Trap:** picking an event you half-know. One follow-up ("why did that move the currency?") and it collapses. Genuinely understand your two.

## Q: "How do you stay up to date with financial news?"

- **What it's really testing:** whether the commercial awareness is a *habit* or was crammed last night.
  - **Structure:** your actual routine → one example of something it taught you → what you do with it.
  - **Skeleton:** *"My honest routine is [true sources — a morning newsletter, a podcast, one paper]. The test of whether it's working: [one thing you learned recently and found genuinely interesting — ideally one of your two warm events]. And I've started [active habit — notes, discussing with a friend, following one sector properly]."*
  - **Humour option:** *"My friends have learned not to ask me what's going on with interest rates unless they've genuinely got ten minutes."*
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## Part 5 — The ethics set

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### Q: "What would you do if you suspected a colleague of something unethical?" / "Tell me about raising a concern"

- **What it's really testing:** *We take responsibility* — which HSBC flags as its most important value, for the very concrete reason you already know from your research: the bank paid ~\$1.9 billion in 2012 for financial-crime failures and rebuilt its whole culture around never repeating them <sup>[9]</sup>. **This question, at this bank, is not hypothetical.** A candidate who understands *why* HSBC cares scores differently from one reciting "I'd tell my manager."
- **The structure — a judgement ladder, not a story:** (1) **don't ignore it** — name that walking past is itself a choice; (2) **check your understanding** — facts first, fairness to the colleague; (3) **escalate through the proper channel** — your manager or the dedicated compliance route, *not* a public confrontation; (4) **why:** protecting clients and the bank *is* the job.
- **Skeleton:** *"I'd start from the principle that noticing and doing nothing is itself a decision. First I'd make sure I'd actually understood what I saw — it's easy to misread something. If the concern held, I'd raise it through the proper channel — my manager, or compliance directly if it involved my manager. I wouldn't confront it publicly or investigate solo. And honestly, this is one of the reasons HSBC makes sense to me: it learned the hard way how much this matters, and it rebuilt itself around getting it right — I'd want to be part of that culture, not a risk to it."*
- **That last sentence is your quiet standout** — it turns a compliance answer into a *why*-HSBC answer. Use it only if it's true for you.
- **Trap:** vigilante energy ("I'd confront them and demand answers"). Calm process beats drama every time.

- **No humour in this one.** This is the single question where a joke costs you. Warm and serious.
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## Part 6 — The written email task (yes, it's a "question" too)

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The simulation ends with a **free-text email** — typically a reply to a manager or colleague, capped around 3,000 characters, "as if you're already on the job" <sup>[1]</sup><sup>[2]</sup>. It's scored on written communication, prioritisation and judgement — and remember: **copy-paste is blocked, so you type it live** <sup>[10]</sup>.

**The four-move structure:** 1. **Acknowledge** — one line: what they asked, that you're on it. (*"Thanks — picking this up now. On the three points you raised:"*) 2. **Prioritise / triage** — deal with the most urgent thing first, and say *why it's first*. Visible triage is exactly what's being marked. 3. **Recommend with reasoning** — use whatever data or documents the simulation gave you. One clear recommendation per point, each with a one-line "because." 4. **Own the next step** — who does what by when, and what you'll come back with. (*"I'll confirm X with the client by Thursday and flag anything that changes the picture."*)

**Style rules:** short paragraphs or numbered points; professional but human (write like a capable colleague, not a legal notice); no unexplained jargon; and land under the character cap with room to spare — a tight 2,000 beats a bloated 2,900. **No humour in the email** — warmth yes ("happy to pick this up"), jokes no.

**Practice once before the real thing:** set a 10-minute timer, invent a scenario ("manager asks: which of these three client requests do we handle first and why?"), and type — don't draft elsewhere — a four-move reply.

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## Part 7 — The master cheat-sheet

| Question                  | Real probe                                 | Structure                               | Your one standout move                     |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Tell me about yourself    | communication                              | Present → Path → Future                 | end pointing at the client-facing role     |
| Why HSBC / why this role  | motivation                                 | 15-sec contents section (see other doc) | named deal + one number                    |
| New senior team           | <i>succeed together + value difference</i> | mindset → actions → over time           | "listen first, deliver small things early" |
| Teamwork                  | <i>succeed together</i>                    | STAR + friction                         | credit someone else by role                |
| Leadership                | <i>get it done + responsibility</i>        | STAR, "nobody asked me"                 | define leadership as initiative            |
| Didn't go to plan         | <i>responsibility + honesty</i>            | STAR, split result                      | own your slice; behavioural change line    |
| Decision, incomplete info | judgement                                  | STAR, visible method                    | "make it reversible, then decide"          |
| Challenged my view        | <i>value difference</i>                    | STAR, the hinge moment                  | outcome <i>better</i> than your plan       |
| Strengths                 | strengths + consistency                    | one strength → proof → fit              | connect to the Relationship Manager job    |
| Weakness                  | self-awareness                             | real → steps → progress                 | small true example, light touch            |
| Energises you / free time | strengths                                  | truth → driver → light bridge           | just be true; the driver is the answer     |
| Macro event               | commercial                                 | event → transmission → so-what → view   | the HSBC so-what from your research        |
| Staying up to date        | commercial habit                           | routine → example → active habit        | your warm event doubles as proof           |

| Question      | Real probe            | Structure                                 | Your one standout move                |
|---------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Ethics        | <i>responsibility</i> | the judgement ladder                      | the "HSBC learned the hard way" close |
| Written email | judgement + writing   | acknowledge → triage →<br>recommend → own | say <i>why</i> item one is first      |

(The "new senior team" question — how you'd introduce yourself to senior colleagues you've never met — got its full breakdown in the video-interview playbook: lead with listening, offer help on small things early, deliver reliably to build credibility [\[3\]](#).)

## Humour placement across the whole assessment — the map

**One light touch total per answer, and not every answer.** Best homes: the intro, the weakness, free time, and the "why HSBC" warmth beat. Acceptable: teamwork scene-setting, the macro-news habit question. **Never:** the ethics question, the failure question's ownership beat, or the written email. If in doubt on the day — warmth over wit, every time.

## The night-before checklist

- Story bank: 6–8 true stories, tagged to values, each follow-up-proof.
- Two warm news events, re-checked that morning.
- Your three flags for "why HSBC" (deal · term · number).
- One strength with proof; one real weakness with steps.
- The decoder in your head: *probe* → *story* → *four beats*.
- Environment: quiet, lit from the front, one device, home connection, calculator and paper, warm-up done properly. Then trust the structure — and let the takes be imperfect, because imperfect is what authentic sounds like.

## Honesty notes

- All model skeletons are **INFERRED** coaching — adapt them into your own words and your own true stories; HSBC requires that you can explain and reproduce anything you submit, and prohibits reading generated answers on camera [\[5\]](#)[\[6\]](#).
- Question likelihoods are drawn from the candidate-reported bank compiled in your video-interview playbook [\[3\]](#); the exact wording on the day will differ — that's what the decoder is for.

- Whether the warm-up question is scored is genuinely disputed in the sources — treat it as scored [2].
- The values framework and STAR guidance are HSBC's own [4][7]; the strengths/consistency mechanism is Cappfinity's stated methodology [8]; the 2012 settlement facts are from the United States Department of Justice [9].

## Source list

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1. Psychometric Success — HSBC Online Job Simulation (structure; email task) — <https://psychometric-success.com/aptitude-tests/test-types/hsbc-online-job-simulation>
  2. JobTestPrep — HSBC Job Simulation / assessment centre (exercises; warm-up-may-be-scored caution) — <https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/hsbc-assessment-centre>
  3. Your video-interview playbook's compiled question bank (MockQuestions, Wall Street Oasis, The Student Room, Glassdoor — full citations there) — see [hsbc-video-interview-playbook.pdf](#)
  4. HSBC — Application hints and tips (STAR verbatim; examples need not be from work) — <https://www.hsbc.com/careers/application-hints-and-tips>
  5. HSBC — same page: acceptable and unacceptable AI use (no generated responses in recorded interviews; explain/validate/replicate) — <https://www.hsbc.com/careers/application-hints-and-tips>
  6. Cappfinity help desk — assessed video responses cannot be re-recorded — <https://capphelpdesk.zendesk.com/hc/en-us/articles/4402640631953-Will-I-be-able-to-re-record-a-video-response>
  7. HSBC — Our values (We value difference · We succeed together · We take responsibility · We get it done) — <https://www.hsbc.com/who-we-are/our-strategy-and-values/our-values>
  8. Cappfinity — The Scientific Origins of Skills & Strengths, Edition 8 (strengths = performance + energy; authenticity/consistency) — [https://files.strengthsprofile.com/Deployable/LocalizableResources/en-gb/Resources/Edition8CappfinitySkillsSeries-ScientificOriginasofSkillsandStrengths\\_UK.pdf](https://files.strengthsprofile.com/Deployable/LocalizableResources/en-gb/Resources/Edition8CappfinitySkillsSeries-ScientificOriginasofSkillsandStrengths_UK.pdf)
  9. United States Department of Justice — HSBC anti-money-laundering settlement (~\$1.9 billion, December 2012) — <https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/hsbc-holdings-plc-and-hsbc-bank-usa-na-admit-anti-money-laundering-and-sanctions-violations>
  10. Cappfinity — integrity features incl. copy prevention (type answers live) — <https://cappfinity.com/integrity-features/>
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*Compiled 12 August 2026. Built on the verified research in your earlier briefings; every skeleton is a scaffold for your own words, not a script. Structure you know cold + words that vary each take = the combination that wins a one-take, authenticity-checked video.*

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Self-contained briefing · rendered from `hsbc-assessment-briefing.md` · 8 August 2026. Reliability labels reflect the evidence at that date; HSBC's process changes frequently.